advertising. Modi, though, wasn't going to take no for an answer. 'He was extremely persuasive. Besides, I liked him, felt he was good for India and wanted him to win. I just couldn't say no this time!'

When Pandey returned home to Mumbai, Piyush Goyal, the BJP's treasurer, who was emerging as a key point person in the media strategy, was waiting for him with the contract. Two hours later, the deal was done.

Pandey would design and oversee the campaign but in his personal capacity. Soho Square, a subsidiary of O&M, would handle the BJP account. Madison, headed by another advertising world powerhouse, Sam Balsara, would do the media buying and planning. For the next three months—from February to May—this crack team, assisted by BJP party leaders, well-wishers and professionals, would put together an advertising campaign of the kind an Indian election had never seen. There would be eighteen-hour days and long nights, but there was a single-minded obsession—to make Brand Modi simply unassailable.

When the creative team began planning the strategy, they had three clear goals in mind. First, position Modi as a credible, decisive leader; second, swing public sentiment among fence sitters; and third, create a wave that would push the BJP beyond 272. The approach would be two-fold—target the public anger against the UPA-II government, and then create a sense of hope that Modi would usher in change. Anger and hope would become the twin planks of the advertising assault.

By the third week of February, Pandey's team was ready with its presentation. The BJP had set up a war room in Delhi at 1, Lodhi Estate, a cosy Lutyens bungalow near the busy Khan Market which had been assigned to its Goa MP, Shripad Naik. The power elite of the BJP gathered to watch the ad pitch. Jaitley, Swaraj, Shah, Goyal, Nirmala Sitharaman were joined by pro-Modi business executives like Sunil Alagh, right-leaning columnists Swapan Dasgupta and Ashok Malik, and new BJP entrants M.J. Akbar and Hardeep Puri.

With so many influential voices in one room, there was bound to be some disagreement. Should the campaign slogan be, as the ad agency was suggesting, '*Abki Baar Modi Sarkar*', or should it be '*Abki Baar Bhajpa*